MODULE 33 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

# Confusion Pairs

Twenty look-alike concepts set side by side, the one detail that separates each pair, and eleven scenarios where changing one detail flips the answer.

SCOPE All seven domains FOCUS Look-alike concepts MODULE 33 of 38

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You tell identical twins apart by the one thing that differs. **Learn the tell, not the whole description.**

# Architecture pairs

| PAIR | CHOOSE THE FIRST WHEN | CHOOSE THE SECOND WHEN |
|---|---|---|
| Workflow or agent | The steps are known in advance | The path depends on what it finds |
| Orchestrator-workers or routing | Subtasks appear only after reading the input | Each input goes to one known handler |
| MCP or direct API | Many clients or agents reuse the capability | One application, one integration |
| MCP or agent-to-agent | You need a lookup or an action | Another agent owns the outcome |

THE TELL

Ask who decides the path, and when it becomes known.

# Context pairs

| PAIR | CHOOSE THE FIRST WHEN | CHOOSE THE SECOND WHEN |
|---|---|---|
| Caching, retrieval or summarising | Same large content every request; or a corpus, parts per request | Long history must continue: summarise |
| Skill or MCP | A procedure or knowledge to follow | Access to a live system or data |
| Skill or system prompt | Loaded only when relevant, shared, versioned | Always on, for every request |
| Tool search or fewer tools | Many tools genuinely needed, few per task | Unused or overlapping tools: remove them |

THE TELL

Ask whether the content is the same every time, needed in part, or needed live.

# Retrieval and testing pairs

| PAIR | CHOOSE THE FIRST WHEN | CHOOSE THE SECOND WHEN |
|---|---|---|
| Dense, sparse or hybrid | Meaning and paraphrase: dense | Exact codes and names: sparse; both: hybrid |
| Regression or smoke test | Before release: does old behaviour still work? | After deploy: is it alive and sane? |
| Integration or adversarial test | Do the components work together? | Can someone make it misbehave? |
| Capability or regression eval | A hill to climb, starting low | A floor to protect, near a hundred percent |

THE TELL

Ask when the test runs, and what failure it is looking for.

# Measurement and value pairs

| PAIR | CHOOSE THE FIRST WHEN | CHOOSE THE SECOND WHEN |
|---|---|---|
| pass@k or pass^k | A person retries and keeps the best | Every attempt must succeed |
| Efficiency or productivity | Each task is faster | More valuable output is delivered |
| Productivity or transformation | Same process, more output | Roles or services are redesigned |
| SLO or SLA | Internal target, stricter | External promise, with consequences |

THE TELL

Ask who relies on the result, and what actually changed.

# Governance and platform pairs

| PAIR | CHOOSE THE FIRST WHEN | CHOOSE THE SECOND WHEN |
|---|---|---|
| HIPAA-ready or ZDR | Ineligible features are blocked with an error | Features outside it still run, but leave the arrangement |
| Preventive or detective control | Stops it happening: limits, denies, validation | Finds it afterwards: logs, alerts, sampling |
| Managed or project scope | Nobody may override it | Shared by everyone in the repository |
| Local or user scope | You, in this project only | You, in every project |

THE TELL

Ask whether the control stops it, or finds it. Ask whether the platform blocks, or trusts you.

# Model and request pairs

| PAIR | CHOOSE THE FIRST WHEN | CHOOSE THE SECOND WHEN |
|---|---|---|
| Orchestrator-workers or parallelisation | Subtasks set at runtime | Subtasks fixed in advance |
| Effort or model tier | Same model, faster, cheaper | A different capability level |
| max_tokens or context window | Limits what Claude writes | Limits what the request holds |
| Batch or fast mode | Can wait a day, half price | Output speed, at a premium |

THE TELL

Ask what you are really changing: subtasks, model, output or wait.

# Separating a pair under pressure

- **Name both candidates** before you choose.
- **Recall the tell** for that pair, from the tables.
- **Find the detail** in the scenario that answers the tell.
- **Ignore the shared description;** both options will match it.
- **Then flip it:** what one change would make the other answer right?

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If you can say what would flip the answer, you understood why it is right.

> Mereside's mortgage document extraction always does the same steps: classify the document, extract fields, validate them, and hand the pack to an underwriter.

## Which pattern fits this work?

A. A fixed workflow of model calls with validation gates between steps

B. An autonomous agent that decides its own steps for each pack

C. A team of agents coordinated by an orchestrator

D. A router that sends each pack to a specialist agent

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which pattern fits this work?

A. A fixed workflow of model calls with validation gates between steps
Known steps: a workflow.

B. An autonomous agent that decides its own steps for each pack
*Freedom it does not need.*

C. A team of agents coordinated by an orchestrator
*Cost without benefit.*

D. A router that sends each pack to a specialist agent
*Adds a hop for one known path.*

THE SIGNAL

Known steps mean a workflow. A path that depends on findings means an agent.

> Tallyhawk's support tickets fall into a few known types: how-to, billing and integration faults.
>
> Each type has its own specialist prompt and tools.

## Which pattern fits this work?

A Orchestrator-workers, which plans subtasks for each ticket

B Parallel calls that vote on the best answer

C One large prompt that handles every type

D Routing: classify each ticket, then send it to its specialist

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE


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## Which pattern fits this work?

A Orchestrator-workers, which plans subtasks for each ticket

*Subtasks are not unknown here.*

B Parallel calls that vote on the best answer

*Voting adds cost, not routing.*

C One large prompt that handles every type

*Mixes prompts and tools for every type.*

D Routing: classify each ticket, then send it to its specialist

Known types, one handler each.

THE SIGNAL

One known handler per input means routing. Subtasks found only by reading means orchestrator-workers.

> Every Quillon portal request includes the same twenty-page appointments and billing policy, unchanged for months.
>
> Cost and latency are both too high.

## What should Corvane apply first?

A Prompt caching, with the policy in a stable prefix

B Retrieval, fetching only the relevant policy sections

C A summary of the policy in place of the full text

D Fine-tuning a model on the policy text

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## What should Corvane apply first?

A Prompt caching, with the policy in a stable prefix

Same content every time: cache it.

B Retrieval, fetching only the relevant policy sections

*Adds a pipeline for a small, stable text.*

C A summary of the policy in place of the full text

*Loses detail patients ask about.*

D Fine-tuning a model on the policy text

*Does not cut repeated input cost.*

THE SIGNAL

Same content every request means caching. A large corpus needed in part means retrieval.

> Several Tallyhawk teams want their agents to follow the same release-notes writing procedure.
>
> It has rules, examples and a checklist, and changes a few times a year.

## How should it be packaged?

A An MCP server that exposes the procedure as a tool

B A paragraph pasted into every agent's system prompt

C A fine-tuned model trained on past release notes

D A Skill, versioned and loaded when relevant

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## How should it be packaged?

A An MCP server that exposes the procedure as a tool

*MCP is for live systems.*

B A paragraph pasted into every agent's system prompt

*Always loaded, copied, drifting.*

C A fine-tuned model trained on past release notes

*Slow to change, hard to audit.*

D A Skill, versioned and loaded when relevant

A procedure, shared and versioned.

THE SIGNAL

A procedure to follow is a Skill. Access to a live system is MCP.

> Tallyhawk has just deployed a new prompt version to production.
>
> The team wants a quick check, right now, that the agent is up and answering sensibly.

## Which test fits this moment?

A The full regression suite, run against the evaluation set

B A smoke test of a few known questions against the deployed system

C An adversarial red-team exercise

D An integration test of every tool call

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which test fits this moment?

A The full regression suite, run against the evaluation set

*Belongs before release.*

B A smoke test of a few known questions against the deployed system

Alive and sane, straight after deploy.

C An adversarial red-team exercise

*Slow, and a different question.*

D An integration test of every tool call

*Narrower, and not the deployed whole.*

THE SIGNAL

After deploy, alive and sane: smoke. Before release, old behaviour holds: regression.

> Tallyhawk's billing agent changes customers' subscriptions.
>
> Customers rely on every single change being right.

## Which metric should gate release?

A pass@k, success in at least one of k attempts

B Average accuracy across all test cases

C pass^k, success on every one of k attempts

D A text-similarity score against reference answers

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which metric should gate release?

A pass@k, success in at least one of k attempts
*Rewards a lucky retry.*

B Average accuracy across all test cases
*Hides unreliable cases.*

C pass^k, success on every one of k attempts
Every attempt must succeed.

D A text-similarity score against reference answers
*Similar is not correct.*

THE SIGNAL

Every attempt must succeed: pass^k. A person retries and keeps the best: pass@k.

> Corvane is briefing Harrowgate Legal and Quillon Health on their platform arrangements.
>
> Harrowgate has zero data retention. Quillon has a HIPAA-ready organisation.

**Which two statements are correct? Choose two.**

A Under zero data retention, ineligible features are blocked with an error

B A HIPAA-ready organisation can send health data to any feature

C In a HIPAA-ready organisation, ineligible features return an error

D Zero data retention and HIPAA coverage are the same arrangement

E Under zero data retention, a feature outside it still runs, but steps outside the arrangement

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which two statements are correct? Choose two.

A Under zero data retention, ineligible features are blocked with an error

*That is HIPAA-ready behaviour.*

B A HIPAA-ready organisation can send health data to any feature

*Only eligible features.*

C In a HIPAA-ready organisation, ineligible features return an error

Blocked, with an error.

D Zero data retention and HIPAA coverage are the same arrangement

*Different arrangements.*

E Under zero data retention, a feature outside it still runs, but steps outside the arrangement

Not blocked; the user must avoid it.

THE SIGNAL

HIPAA-ready blocks ineligible features. ZDR trusts you to avoid them.

> Mereside reviews a year of results from complaints triage and agent assist.

**Which two observations show productivity rather than efficiency? Choose two.**

A Complaint handlers close a quarter more cases each week, with the same staff

B Draft replies take minutes instead of a quarter of an hour

C The keying role was retired, and its staff now run broker support

D Advisers resolve more calls per shift than before

E Average handle time per call has fallen

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which two observations show productivity rather than efficiency? Choose two.

**A** Complaint handlers close a quarter more cases each week, with the same staff

More output delivered.

**B** Draft replies take minutes instead of a quarter of an hour

*Faster per task: efficiency.*

**C** The keying role was retired, and its staff now run broker support

*A redesigned role: transformation.*

**D** Advisers resolve more calls per shift than before

More output delivered.

**E** Average handle time per call has fallen

*Faster per task: efficiency.*

THE SIGNAL

Faster tasks are efficiency. More delivered is productivity. New roles are transformation.

> Corvane is reviewing controls on Tallyhawk's billing agent.

**Which two are preventive controls? Choose two.**

A. A daily review of sampled tool-call logs

B. A code-enforced limit on the size of any credit

C. The bulk-refund tool removed from the agent entirely

D. An alert on unusual refund volumes

E. A monthly audit of issued credits

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which two are preventive controls? Choose two.

A. A daily review of sampled tool-call logs
*Finds problems afterwards.*

B. A code-enforced limit on the size of any credit
Stops it happening.

C. The bulk-refund tool removed from the agent entirely
Stops it happening.

D. An alert on unusual refund volumes
*Finds it afterwards.*

E. A monthly audit of issued credits
*Finds it afterwards.*

THE SIGNAL

Preventive stops it happening. Detective finds it afterwards. Strong designs use both.

> Corvane is drafting Quillon's portal service documents.
>
> Some items belong in the contract with Quillon, others in Corvane's internal operations.

**Which two belong in the external SLA? Choose two.**

A. An internal latency target of one and a half seconds

B. The error-budget policy for pausing releases

C. The on-call rota for the run team

D. The service credit due on a breach

E. First token within two seconds at the ninety-fifth percentile, monthly

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which two belong in the external SLA? Choose two.

A An internal latency target of one and a half seconds
*Internal SLO.*

B The error-budget policy for pausing releases
*Internal practice.*

C The on-call rota for the run team
*Internal practice.*

D The service credit due on a breach
External consequence.

E First token within two seconds at the ninety-fifth percentile, monthly
External promise.

THE SIGNAL

The SLA holds the promise and the consequence. The SLO and error budget run inside.

> Tallyhawk wants a summary of every support conversation from the day, ready for a morning operations report.
>
> Nobody reads the summaries until the next morning.

## Which option fits best?

A Fast mode, so the summaries are generated as quickly as possible

B The Batch API, submitted each evening and collected the next morning

C A more capable model tier, run in real time as conversations end

D Streaming responses, so each summary appears word by word

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which option fits best?

A Fast mode, so the summaries are generated as quickly as possible

*Pays a premium for speed nobody needs.*

B The Batch API, submitted each evening and collected the next morning

Can wait, half price.

C A more capable model tier, run in real time as conversations end

*More cost, no benefit here.*

D Streaming responses, so each summary appears word by word

*Perceived speed for a reader who is not there.*

THE SIGNAL

Work that can wait goes to Batch. Output speed that matters to a waiting user is fast mode.

# In five lines

- **Learn the tell,** not the whole description.
- **Path known in advance:** workflow. One handler per input: routing.
- **Same content each time:** cache. Procedure: Skill. Live system: MCP.
- **After deploy:** smoke. Every attempt matters: pass^k.
- **Stops it:** preventive. HIPAA-ready blocks; ZDR trusts you.

> COMING UP
>
> Next: what changed since the exam guide was published.